

Chicken Curry

Onion-forward · garlic-forward · no tomato, no yogurt · stovetop bhuna

YIELD	ACTIVE	ONION RATIO	FAT RATIO
6–8	~1.25 hr	1:1 to protein	10% of protein

KEY TARGETS

visual states — the bhuna is judged by eye, not clock

Onion paste	Deep brown, jammy — ~75% volume loss, smell sweet not sharp.
Bhuna (masala)	Oil separates — paste goes curdled & matte, clear oil pools in "craters" and at the edges.
Sauce	Clings to the meat, coats a spoon — body comes from the reduced onion, not dairy.
Garlic finish	Hits the nose immediately on serving.
Final	Thick, glossy, not watery.

INGREDIENTS

1.5 kg chicken batch

Chicken boneless thigh, chunked	1.5 kg	Garlic minced, for finish	30 g
Onion sliced thin	1.5 kg	Salt ~12g at sear, rest to taste	18 g
Ghee (100 + 30 + 20)	150 g	Lemon juice the acid lever — to taste	15 g+
Ginger-garlic paste DIY, below	60 g	Kasuri methi crushed	2–3 g
		Green chilies slit	2–3

SPICES

whole = bloom (step 4) · ground = fry in fat (step 5)

WHOLE — BLOOM, STEP 4

Cumin seed	6 g
Green cardamom	4 pods
Black cardamom	2 pods
Cinnamon	1 stick
Bay	3 leaves
Cloves	4

GROUND — FRY IN FAT, STEP 5

Kashmiri chili color, mild	30 g
Hot chili	7 g
Turmeric	4 g

GARAM MASALA — USED IN TWO STAGES

Bloom half with ground spices, step 5	3.5 g
Finish half off heat, step 10	3.5 g

DIY ginger-garlic paste: 60g garlic + 60g ginger (1:1), peeled. Blend with **15–30 ml water** — minimum to form a smooth paste. Yield ~120g; use 60g here. Keeps **5–7 days** fridge, **3 months** frozen. Turns bitter after 24 hr at room temp — fresh is brighter.

Build the Curry

METHOD

stovetop — oil separation gates every stage

- 1 **Onions:** 100g ghee, add onions. **50–60 min medium**, stir every 5–7 min. Done: volume down ~75%, no steam releasing, smell sweet not sharp, color deep brown & jammy.
- 2 **Blend:** tilt the pot, immersion-blend the onions to a smooth paste in the residual fat — no water. (Traditional blender: remove center cap, cover with towel, vent steam.)
- 3 **Fry the paste (bhuna):** 30g ghee, return paste, **8–10 min medium**, stir constantly. Done: paste looks **curdled and matte**, clear oil pools in "craters" and at the edges. Non-negotiable — rushing = raw taste.
- 4 **Bloom:** push paste to the sides, add whole spices to the fat in the center, **30–45 sec** until fragrant and sizzling, stir in. Add 60g ginger-garlic paste, **2–3 min** until the raw smell is gone.
- 5 **Ground spices:** medium-low. Add the ground spices + the **first 3.5g garam masala (bloom half)**. Fry **45–60 sec** in the fat. Splash **50 ml water**, cook until oil separates.
- 6 **Sear:** high heat. Add chicken to the fried masala, season with **~12g salt** (hold the rest). Sear **4–5 min** until opaque — building fond.
- 7 **Simmer:** add **~300 ml hot water**, scrape up the fond, cover and simmer until the chicken is cooked through — **~15–20 min** for thigh chunks. Stir once or twice.
- 8 **Reduce:** uncover, medium-high. Reduce until the sauce clings to the chicken, **8–12 min**. Now taste and bring to **final salt** (the held ~6g, to taste) — after reduction, not before.
- 9 **Garlic finish:** small pan, 20g ghee + 30g minced garlic + slit chilies. **60–90 sec** to just-golden edges (not brown). Pour into the curry.
- 10 **Finish:** off heat. Add the **second 3.5g garam masala (finish half)**, kasuri methi, 15g lemon. The garlic should hit your nose immediately.

TROUBLESHOOTING

every fault traces to the bhuna or the reduction

PROBLEM	CAUSE	FIX
Watery / thin sauce	Under-reduced onions; bhuna rushed	Reduce longer at step 8; oil must separate at steps 3 & 5
Tastes raw / flat	Bhuna rushed; bloom skipped	No shortcuts on oil separation; bloom the spices in fat
No garlic punch	Finish garlic overcooked	Golden edges only, not brown; add right before serving
Too hot / dry	Chili concentrated; not enough fat	Add 20–30g ghee — NOT water. Fat mellows heat.
Flat / one-note rich	No acid now that yogurt's gone	Lemon to taste at the finish — it's the only acid lever; green chilies help too